self-esteem, especially someone who didn't think he'd done anything to provoke it. I refused and said I'd go back inside the Carrington complex. I walked back across the training fields, got dressed and went out to my car. Something made me stop, though. *It's a big game on Saturday. Don't make things worse. Be professional about this.*

I went back inside, got changed again and went into the gym to work on my own. After about half an hour, Roy Keane came through on his way back to the dressing room. I wasn't sure what was going on or how I should be reacting. I asked Roy what he thought I should do. He said it straight out:

'You should go and talk to the manager.'

It was what Roy would have done himself. I should have ignored his advice. I went to the manager's office, knocked on the door and walked into the biggest dressing down I've ever had in my career. As he saw it, I had my priorities all wrong. I apologized for feeling how I did about the situation but I didn't back down.

'It's not that I didn't want to be here at work but, as I see it, my first priority has to be my family. My son was ill and that's why I missed training.'

The boss thought differently:

'Your responsibilities are here at the club, not at home with your son.'

Don't get me wrong: I could see the manager's point of view, with the whole club to think about at an important time in the season, even if I didn't agree with him. What really tipped a big argument over into becoming a blazing dispute was a photo in that day's papers of Victoria at a charity function on the Thursday night: the evening after the morning I'd missed training. By tea-time, Brooklyn had been back to his usual self and Victoria had decided, while he slept, to honor a long-standing commitment which meant her being away from the house for a couple of hours. That wasn't how the boss saw it, though:

'You were babysitting while your wife was out gallivanting.'

That word: gallivanting. It was the sneering tone I thought came with it that made me flip:

'Don't talk about my wife like that. How would you feel if I was disrespectful like that about your wife?'